

**“The physicists have
known sin ... a knowledge
which they cannot lose.”**

J. Robert Oppenheimer, 1947

their concept would later prove vital in simplifying equations used to calculate the energy of a molecule. Oppenheimer held postgraduate roles at the California

Institute of Technology (Caltech) and at Harvard, as well as in the Netherlands and Switzerland, before settling in the US in 1929 to teach at Caltech and Berkeley.

Nuclear dawn

Oppenheimer's research ranged from energy processes in subatomic particles—including cosmic rays, electrons, and positrons—to black holes and neutron stars. Yet it was the 1939 discovery of nuclear fission by Lise Meitner (see pp.194–197) and Otto Hahn that would definitively shape his career.

